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Rose-breasted Grosbeak

*Pheucticus ludovicianus***QUICK STATS**

Length	7.1 – 8.3 in (18 – 21 cm)
Wingspan	11.4 – 13.0 in (29 – 33 cm)
Weight	1.4 – 1.7 oz (39 – 49 g)
Lifespan	Up to 24 years (avg. 7 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Rose-breasted Grosbeak is one of the most stunning birds to appear at eastern feeders — the male's combination of jet-black head, bright white body, and brilliant rose-red triangular breast patch is one of the most striking plumage patterns in North American ornithology. Its arrival at sunflower feeders in early May, coinciding with peak spring migration, is one of the most eagerly anticipated events of the backyard birding year. Adding to its appeal, the male sings a rich, melodious song described as a "robin who has had singing lessons" — flowing phrases delivered with unusual sweetness and complexity. Females, by contrast, resemble large streaked sparrows and are often overlooked.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Rose-breasted Grosbeak breeds across southern Canada and the northeastern United States, from British Columbia east to Nova Scotia and south through the Appalachians and Great Plains. It is a long-distance migrant, wintering from Mexico through Central America to northern South America. It inhabits mature deciduous and mixed forests, forest edges, riparian woodlands, orchards, and suburban gardens with large trees. It passes through a broad migratory corridor across the eastern and central United States each spring and fall.

DIET & FEEDING

- Black-oil sunflower seeds — the top feeder food, strongly preferred
- Sunflower chips and safflower seeds
- Wild berries and small fruits during migration and on wintering grounds
- Insects and larvae — the bulk of the summer breeding diet
- Weed seeds and wild grain in migration
- Flower buds and nectar occasionally in spring

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Rose-breasted Grosbeaks are somewhat shy and deliberate at feeders, typically visiting in the early morning and late afternoon. Males are territorial on the breeding grounds but relatively tolerant of other species. They are powerful seed-crackers — their large, conical bill can split open hard seeds with ease. During migration they may appear at feeders in small groups of 5–10 birds, sometimes including both sexes and immature males with pinkish-orange breast washes. They spend most of their time in the mid-to-upper canopy and may be difficult to observe despite their loud song.

NESTING & BREEDING

Rose-breasted Grosbeaks build a loosely constructed, somewhat flimsy cup nest of twigs and plant stems in a tree fork or dense shrub, typically 5–20 feet above the ground. Clutches of 3–5 pale blue-green eggs with brown spots are incubated by both parents for 13–14 days — a rare behavior in songbirds. Both parents share equally in brooding and feeding the nestlings, which fledge at 9–12 days. Males sometimes sing softly while incubating. One brood per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Rose-breasted Grosbeak's song is a rich, flowing series of melodious whistled phrases — sweeter and more polished than an American Robin's, delivered with a liquid quality that is instantly recognizable once learned. Both sexes sing — the female's song is softer but similar in structure. The call is a distinctive, sharp "squeaky sneaker" sound — a useful identification clue in migration when birds pass overhead.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining
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The Rose-breasted Grosbeak population is estimated at 4.1 million individuals and has declined by approximately 35% since 1970. Loss of mature deciduous forest on both breeding and wintering grounds is the primary threat. Window collisions during migration are a significant additional mortality source. Planting large native trees and maintaining sunflower feeders during the May migration window are meaningful ways to support this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Stock sunflower feeders by late April — males arrive in early May
- A large hopper or platform feeder with sunflower seeds is ideal
- Rose-breasted Grosbeaks visit feeders most actively at dawn and dusk
- Watch for females — they look like large, streaky sparrows with a big pale bill
- Apply window decals in May — this species is highly vulnerable to glass strikes

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Head (male)	Glossy black — hood
Breast patch (male)	Rose-red triangle — key field mark
Back & wings (male)	Black with white wing patches
Belly (male)	White
Female — overall	Brown, streaked; white supercilium
Bill	Large, conical, pale gray

COLOR ME!

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